Paula Ingabire

(een-gah-BEE-ray)

Minister of ICT and Innovation
Republic of Rwanda

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Oct 2018**

Paula Ingabire is a dynamic leader whose confidence about integrating emerging technologies and her high-profile public engagements have added to Rwanda's reputation for innovation and results-driven development.

- **Tech Enthusiast**
  Ingabire is relentless in her pursuit of new technologies and initiatives, including robots, drones, smart cities, augmented and virtual reality, telemedicine, and artificial intelligence.

- **Global Partnerships**
  Her ability to frame Rwanda's ICT initiatives within a developmental context and her partnerships with tech giants and international organizations makes her a crucial bridge between Rwanda and the global tech community.

Ingabire positions her country as a testbed for scalable solutions. She has stressed that "it's not about just creating the solution for Rwanda, it's also finding ways to scale that solution beyond just Rwanda."

WHY THEY MATTER

Ingabire is at the forefront of Rwanda's efforts to leverage technology for positive outcomes in the agriculture sector, touting her country as a model for digital innovation.

- **AgTech Pioneer**
  Ingabire has prioritized AI-enabled agricultural solutions, including early weather warning systems, satellite imagery for crop monitoring, and soil health data. Under her ministry, Rwanda is deploying machine learning and satellite imaging to predict yields for maize, potatoes, and rice.

- **Scaling Hub**
  Ingabire in 2025 secured a $7.5 million partnership with the Gates Foundation to build the Rwanda AI Scaling Hub, a center that will develop AI opportunities in sectors like agriculture, health, and education. She is also working with MTN Rwanda to enable farmers to pay for fertilisers using the Smart Nkunganire system and access weather-related information

Ingabire is an avid backer of regional cooperation, coordinating the creation of Smart Africa to leverage broadband infrastructure as a driver for Africa's socio- economic growth. At the World Economy Forum, she said a regional approach is key to address resource constraints and facilitate cross-border data flow.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Ingabire is known for her composed and professional demeanor, blending technocratic expertise with a passion for innovation.

- **Optimism Over Pessimism**
  While acknowledging challenges, she maintains an overall optimistic outlook about Rwanda's digital transformation. She often talks about a “bright future” and encourages her counterparts to put on a "positive lens” to see the opportunities in front of them.

- **Action Over Perfection**
  Ingabire emphasizes Rwanda's "proof-of-concept" approach: "We do not necessarily wait for a perfect environment where you have the right regulations or the funding required to get things done. Even with the constraints that we may have, we still are able to find ways where technology is able to support us."

Ingabire occasionally reveals a more personal side in her interviews and engagements. She uses her own story—"as a tech-enthusiast, a wife and mother of three”—who became a minister in her thirties to inspire young women.

ON THEIR MIND

- **Inclusive FinTech Forum 2026**
  Rwanda will host the Inclusive FinTech Forum 2026 from 10 to 12 March, convening global leaders, innovators, and policymakers for leadership dialogues, roundtables, and curated networking, The Forum will provide a platform to exchange ideas and explore solutions that make financial services more accessible and impactful.

- **Gates Foundation Partnership**
  Rwanda will test technology powered by artificial intelligence in more than 50 health clinics as part of a new initiative by the Gates Foundation to support 1,000 clinics across Africa with the aim to improve health care services.

- **Zipline Expansion Deal**
  Rwanda will become the first country with full nationwide autonomous logistics coverage, the first country in Africa with Zipline’s urban delivery system, and the first country in Africa with an autonomous delivery testing center. The expansion is part of Zipline’s recent $150M pay-for-performance award from the U.S. Department of State.

- **Anthropic Partnership**
  Anthropic in late 2024 announced a new partnership with the Government of Rwanda and African tech training provider ALX to bring Chidi—a learning companion built on Claude—to hundreds of thousands of learners across Africa.

NETWORK

Ingabire has a strong global network, capitalizing on platforms such as the World Economic Forum and major international conferences to bolster her reputation as a tech leader.

Ingabire chaired the Global AI Summit on Africa in 2025 and World Telecommunication Development Conference in 2022, which included 2,152 participants from 150 countries. It helped cement Rwanda and her leadership in the tech sector, resulting in the Kigali Declaration and the Kigali Action Plan.

Ingabire is quick to acknowledge President Kagame's leadership, and she works well with fellow ministers and colleagues in her ministry and related government agencies.

She often credits Kagame for his promotion of digital innovation as a cornerstone of Rwanda's development strategy. Her ministry works closely with the Ministry of Agriculture and Animal Resources on digital agriculture initiatives, including the Smart Nkunganire System and drone delivery of agricultural inputs.

CONTROVERSIES

While Ingabire has maintained a relatively positive public profile, she has faced some challenges regarding policy implementation and the pace of digital inclusion.

- **Digital Divide in Rural Areas**
  Critics have pointed out the persistent digital divide in Rwanda, especially between urban and rural areas. While coverage has expanded dramatically, Ingabire herself acknowledges that "many Africans live in areas with coverage but are not accessing the internet" due to affordability and digital literacy gaps.

- **Smart Nkunganire Challenges**
  While the platform has connected 1.9 million farmers, audits have uncovered discrepancies between digital and physical stock balances, potentially caused by internet connectivity issues. There remain challenges in digital supply chain management, financial processes, and user experience.

There also have been concerns about Rwanda's cybersecurity preparedness. At the 2025 Inclusive Fintech Forum, Ingabire warned: "cybercrime has already cost us billions, but beyond the money, it undermines trust and threatens national sovereignty."

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of ICT and Innovation**, Government of Rwanda (2018 to present)
- **Coordinator**, Kigali Innovation City initiative (2015 to 2018)
- **Head of ICT Business Development**, Rwanda Development Board (2014 to 2017)
- **Coordinator**, Smart Africa Secretariat (2013 to 2016)
- **Project and Operations Manager**, Rwanda Development Board (2009 to 2013)

BIO

Paula Ingabire's affinity for technology started in high school computer coding programs. Born on January 24, 1983, in Rwanda, she credits her engineer father for influencing her career path; she fondly recalls doing numerous math exercises at home during holidays.

- **MIT-Trained Engineer**
  She studied Computer Engineering and Information Technology at the College for Science and Technology at the University of Rwanda and earned her master's in engineering and management from Massachusetts Institute of Technology. She was a Systems Design & Management Fellow at MIT.

- **Women Champion**
  Ingabire uses international forums to raise her profile a a proponent for women's empowerment. In 2023, she said "It's one thing to advocate for more women in tech, but it's also important for women to really take their place at the table."

A mother of three children, Ingabire balances her high-profile role with family life. She has stressed the importance of wellness in her professional life, maintaining a regular workout routine 4-5 times a week. Ingabire speaks English and Kinyarwanda fluently and some French.

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